HRDP Phenotyping Pilot Program Application Information

Background
The Hybrid Rat Discovery Panel (HRDP) provides genetic diversity and genetic stability to study complex traits under different environments. To expand the use of the HRDP strains, the Medical College of Wisconsin (MCW) has established pilot programs to generate preliminary data using HRDP animal models. To overcome obstacles that might prevent investigators from selecting a new model or embark on using an entire genetic reference population, a trial run using a group of HRDP strains will allow investigators to determine how well the HRDP strains translate to new research areas. Investigators can request up to 40 individual HRDP rats from four different strains for phenotyping pilot projects to be completed at MCW.

Round 1 Deadline: December 18, 2026 (Midnight CST). Submit completed application to: hrdp@mcw.edu

Decision on Applications: January 2027

Number of Application that can be submitted: Up to two per Principal Investigator per cycle

Number of Applications that will be awarded: Two per cycle

Frequency of Applications: We anticipate two competitive application cycles per year.

Application review: A review committee formed of internal and external advisory board members will review completed applications. Applications will be ranked based on significance and translation to human health, likelihood of obtaining future funding, and the experimental plan.

Pilot Project Start Date: 2 to 4 months after award for most cohorts

Cost to Investigator: Rat cohort and phenotyping services will be provided at no cost.

Application Process

1. Fill out application as outlined below. (Use application template found on website: https://rgd.mcw.edu/rgdweb/hrdp_panel.html)
2. Adhere to page lengths and provide all requested information.
3. Failure to adhere to the guidelines will result in application being returned without review.
4. MCW team will check for completeness and forward qualifying applications to the review committee.
5. The review committee will score each application based on review criteria (see below).
6. Principal Investigators whose applications are not selected will receive a brief summary of the decision and/or the primary reason(s) for non-selection. Applications may be resubmitted during future application cycles.

Application Format

1. High level summary of the proposed project (0.5 page maximum).
2. Justify the need for using the HRDP resource (0.5 page maximum).
3. Specific aims and goals of project (0.5 page maximum).
4. Provide a brief description of proposed phenotyping and experimental design (1 page maximum).
5. HRDP cohort request (maximum of 40 rats total)
6. Expected outcomes of phenotyping project (0.5 page maximum).
7. Funding source(s) to support similar or future projects.

Review Criteria

1. Project summary and need for HRDP cohort
2. Project Goals
3. Phenotyping protocol
4. HRDP cohort
5. Existing funding and/or likelihood to obtain future funding to support similar/future projects

Review Criteria	**Reviewer 1**	**Reviewer 2**	**Reviewer 3**
Project summary & need for HRDP			
Project goals			
Phenotyping protocol			
HRDP cohort			
Existing funds or likelihood			
OVERALL SCORE			

Scoring

Each application will be independently evaluated by three reviewers using the NIH scoring system (1–9, with 1 being the best score) across the established review criteria. Applications will be ranked based on their overall scores, which reflect an integrated assessment of the individual criteria. If applications receive similar or tied overall scores, individual criterion scores will be considered to help determine the final ranking. When applications remain comparable, preference may be given to investigators who have not previously used HRDP resources.